influence in South Asia and the Indian Ocean Region has intensified India's security concerns about China's role and influence in its immediate and extended neighbourhoods. Another element that has re-emerged in India–China relations, along with their heralded rise as major economic and military powers, is their competition for status in the international arena. While acknowledging the influence that these factors exert on India–China relations, this chapter predominantly focuses on India's threat perceptions and responses stemming from the boundary dispute and China's potential military intervention in an India–Pakistan conflict.

State responses to threat: a conceptual framework

Logically, a state could respond to threats to its security and interests in one of three ways. It could conciliate the rival through appeasement in the short term or bandwagon with the latter to avoid grave losses and gain economically and diplomatically from association with a stronger power.[12] Second, a state could choose to compete against the rival by mobilising internal resources (internal balancing) and aggregating power through alliances (external balancing).[13] Two sets of factors determine how efficient the balancing policy of a state is. The first of these is the nature and intensity of the threat posed by the other state, which is a function of its aggregate power and geographical proximity, as well as barriers between the two states, the offensive capabilities of the source of the threat, and how aggressive its intent is.[14] The second set of factors is internal to the balancing state, in terms of the degree of consensus and cohesion among its elites about the source and nature of the threat and how to tackle it, as well as the government's